Once Upon A December (Night)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42977238.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra), Entrapta & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst and Tragedy, Death, Grief/Mourning, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Blood and Violence, Hurt No Comfort, Enemy Lovers, Stargazing, Mutual Pining, Two Shot, Mental Health Issues, Pain before the fun, Let's add a little spice, toxic, Dependency Issues, Unhealthy Relationships, the spice is lemonpepper, just a hint though, Its mild at best, TW Shadow Weaver, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-10 Words: 10,989 Chapters: 1/1

Once Upon A December (Night)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42977238.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra), Entrapta & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst and Tragedy, Death, Grief/Mourning, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Blood and Violence, Hurt No Comfort, Enemy Lovers, Stargazing, Mutual Pining, Two Shot, Mental Health Issues, Pain before the fun, Let's add a little spice, toxic, Dependency Issues, Unhealthy Relationships, the spice is lemonpepper, just a hint though, Its mild at best, TW Shadow Weaver, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-10 Words: 10,989 Chapters: 1/1

Once Upon A December (Night)

by OfSongsandSorrows

Summary

Adora was over it. She had grown tired of years of back and forth, back and forth. Her sword was drawn; Catra's sharp claws were out, ready to pierce the heroine's skin. Adora tried to wipe her mind of Catra and every worry she brought. It was futile, her presence was ingrained into her mind. One she wanted gone and found, one she couldn't seem to let go.

Catra couldn't get enough. One look into Adora's eyes and she spiraled, falling apart at the seams. Her brain muddled, her breath long gone as the realization dawned upon her, in all of its glory and to Catra's horror, she had only one thought.

If Adora wouldn't love her then hate was the next best thing.

Notes

One part of a two shot.

Please enjoy

See the end of the work for more notes

And within the clutches of blind rage, her mind was still.

Things came to that; when the mind and body united in one sensation. Under a fury that exceeded feeling, it had not grown above her, no. It had burned her from the inside-out, leaving behind charred remains of memories and emotions she killed long ago. With every step, and with every beat of her heart, ashes trailed. There was nothing left she could feel to supply her cold, barren form. And thus all was calm, all was quiet, and all was still.

Grass succumbed under the weight of Adora's resolve, sounding heavy pounding throughout what had used to be a luscious forest. A sense of disorientation overtook her. Adora's vision split, the person whom she knew and the person she came to know cleaved into the foe before her. And she did as well.

It was nightfall. Shera drew her sword; discordant cackling came from Catra. Her claws were out, longer and sharper than before. The foe stood apathetic; the heroine pressed forward. Her brows knotted into a look of disdain, focused on the opponent before her. Shera's imposing frame halted inches from the ruffian, who in return gave a look of disinterest and began to pick at her claws. Catra's mouth found itself into a curved smile, and she looked up to Shera's scowl, amused.

Shera studied Catra; the moonlight shone upon her face, standing out her every feature and hair amidst the darkened forest. But those eyes, Shera swore that she had seen them. They had followed, haunted her. Dark yet familiar, in her lone restless nights, they filled her head. Striping Shera of her title, her glory, of her honor, they left Adora suffering through endless tossing and turning. The eyes she once loved, broke her. To reminisce about them brought a suffocating pain that had Adora gripping her chest, begging for air in the dead of night. Those weren't the same eyes of the person whom she used to call a friend years ago. They were icy, empty of anything that could be called vitality. Not a remnant of life was behind the bemusement of her grin.

Chills ran through Shera’s body. Like a hunger that would be satiated whenever she saw Catra, she was helplessly relieved. The initial breath she released once she confirmed Catra’s life would be filled with a constant dread every time that they met. If Catra was alive, then it was to be by Shera’s hands that she met her end.

Had her friend came with her -against everything- maybe things would've been different. Unable to save the person most important to her, and instead take up a weapon against her, left Adora feeling all the more helpless. For the sake of everything Shera stood for, she was ready to strike down the one she once held dearest. It was the very life Adora had always tried to protect, yet there Catra stood, a breath away and still unreachable, as if two worlds had truly divided them. Many times Adora had tried to cross, as did Catra, but lest their hands simply graze each other, their worlds cracked and fell apart. The touch lingered.

Catra was the first to speak, “You're quite pretty today aren’t you Shera?”

She answered, “Cease your madness Catra.”

“Oh please,” Catra let out a short chuckle, “then I’d have to kill you.”

Shera held her breath, her voice unwavering, and put herself into a stance, “Ready yourself.”

“I get a warning this time?” Catra brought her hands out, ready to pounce.

“It was your only one.”

Catra lunged and Shera knocked her from the air with the blunt side of her sword. She fell and rolled onto the sparse grass back into an aggressive stance. Shera pointed her sword at the enemy and began to circle around in defense.

“C’mon. Come and get me!” Catra words ended in another cackle.

Shera said nothing and launched forward, nearly cutting Catra to her own surprise. Catra had side-stepped and her face twisted into a menacing glower. But Shera gave her no time to recover; as quickly as she brought up her sword, she took a step and brought it down. Catra managed to dodge and sneak to her blind spot.

Making the mistake of missing the mark, Shera swiftly turned around and was met with open space. She scanned the area having urgency screaming at her. She didn’t even have the chance to turn back around before Catra was on her. Her shoulders began to buckle under the pressure that Catra’s thighs were placing upon it. Claws dragged against Shera’s cheek; she gave a yell and threw Catra off of her.

Shera kneeled; her hand pressed to the open wound feeling the sickly sensation of blood trickling out. She removed her hand and eyed the blood. It was not a lot, but still managed to cover the great majority of her palm. Looking up, Shera saw Catra standing idly, licking the blood from her claws.

The sight caused an overwhelming urge to vomit. Shera’s relinquished face contorted into a look of pure revulsion, and much to her displeasure, led to Catra painting on another smile.

“It’s a shame, I thought you’d taste just as good as you looked.” She wiped her claws and stuck out her tongue, “Ugh, just as rotten as your princess blood.”

Shera propped herself back up and stood gallantly. Her eyes had dimmed in between her furrowed brows.

“You disgust me.”

“Ha, what’s new?”

Shera went in again, only managing to scrape Catra here and there. Her agility was as good as her evasiveness, she had kept the heroine on her toes.

Catra attacked; within the forestry she pounced from point to point, tree to tree, onto a broken bot and back onto Shera. That time she started from the top right of Shera's back and dug her claws in, ripping the skin making sure the marks were deep enough to leave a scar.

A cry of pain echoed throughout the forest. Shera grabbed Catra by her arm and hurled her into a tree; a loud *slam* and *crunch* was heard upon impact. Shera held her shoulder feeling the pain that had begun to radiate through her. Red, hot pain swarmed her every nerve and clouded her vision. She approached Catra swiftly and stood over her.

Laying against the tree with blood slipping through her mouth, Catra looked up. Shera stood in front of the radiating sun, blocking her features making her all the more intangible and great. Catra retaliated to the suppressive aura by hissing; her fangs all the more sharper and feline,

Raising her sword, Shera had long ago been resigned to the moment. But it was the look in Catra's eye; how fear shone through. Adora caught on in a second and her heart had turned. Something was still beating, something she had forgotten to kill. Pity overtook her despite her knowing very well she should have used the opportunity to finally end the needless dance.

Catra threw up her arms in a pitiful attempt; the sound of a sword cutting permeated through the air. Shera had missed, and planted the sword into the tree behind Catra. She lifted the ruffian's chin, and stared into her eyes, reading them, trying to find *something* . Her labored breathing from her wound was the only sound for mere seconds. The world started to grow hotter and Shera could feel power being drained from her.

But Catra was finally subdued. That had a smirk dance across her face and speak of her boasts.

"I win." She said panting and still smug, "Stand down."

Catra looked thoughtful for a moment before she spat blood onto Shera's cheek.

Instantly Shera's face had fallen into a grimace. She took her thumb and wiped at the spot. Observing her thumb, she frowned; then looking back at Catra, she grinned.

With her other hand Shera grabbed Catra by the jaw and held her tight with an impenetrable grip. Catra clawed her arm, leaving marks deeper than before.

"No! Get your hand off-" she choked out.

Shera ignored the words and held on firm. Prying her adversary's mouth open, she took her thumb and wiped the blood back onto Catra's tongue.

"How do you taste?" She let go of her grip, "Even worse right?"

Catra began coughing and spitting, "You-!"

Shera glanced upon Catra hunched form. Pity had grown, blossomed into anguish. Her expression fell as she continued, "After all of these years… no you force my hand." Shera nearly threw down her sword, exasperated. "But I still don't want to hurt you, Catra; I never did." her voice broke, "But you- But you! It never had to be this way! We could've gone to Brightmoon, we could've been- we could've fought together, was that not what you wanted?"

Catra got up facing the ground, expression undecipherable, "You always wanted me to join you and your stupid group of princesses, but why couldn't you just *stay* ?"

"You still don't get it." Shera scoffed, "How could I when the Horde had been lying to us for years? And here you stand against me even though you know that the Horde is wrong."

"At least they never abandoned me!" Catra's voice sounded wounded, pained even, "You left me. I needed you and you left

me!’

“I tried to get you to leave so many times but you chose to stay!” Shera stopped and before she could filter the thought, it came right out, “…Were you scared?”

Catra lifted her head, “What?”

“Did you not come with me because you were scared?”

“Scared?...Scared?.. Scared?!” Catra looked ready to maim, “I wasn’t going to give up everything I worked for to run around with your sorry excuse of an army and princesses!”

“So you just stay with evil instead of fighting against it? And despite everything we’ve been through, you hated me enough to stay with the Horde?”

Catra’s face warped as if she had been seared by a hot iron, “Oh, just shut up already!”

She dared another attack. Shera tried to grab her sword but ended up kicking Catra back against the tree with a solid *crack.* She had put more strength than she intended into that kick, but supposed it would have been good enough to keep Catra down. Shera quickly went to regain her prized weapon.

She stepped back; it seemed like any and all will had been snatched from her. “Please, I can’t keep doing this…We can’t keep doing this.”

Catra's eyes were glazed over as she held her stomach, her voice was barely higher than a whisper, “I…hate you.”

The words caused fine streaks of tears to run down Shera’s cheek. She let out a pitiful, labored laugh, tired of it all. Her back was on fire, the world was starting to spin, “Get up Catra.” her face grew irritated, “Or do you just enjoy this? Dragging it out to mess with me?”

A serene silence from the absence of an answer met Shera's ears.

The moon shone over Catra's unmoving body, freezing her in time. Shera chose to move forward, completely empty of thought and of a stopped heart. Regardless of every advancing step she took, her mind was unable to comprehend the fatality. She held Catra's body up close, pressing her head against her chest, straining to hear her heart.

But all was still.

That was years ago.

From outside a window Adora could be seen swinging and parrying her sword. With every thrust she imagined her past friend on the receiving end and every time was a jab to her heart. She slashed the air around her as if the memories she recalled would go along with it. Sweat trickled down her brow and her face was knitted together in concentration.

"Hey, Adora!"

Those words had Adora turn sharply on her heel, the tip of her blade met the throat of Glimmer.

"Whoa! Hey, calm down!" Glimmer had exclaimed being centimeters away from the sword.

With ragged breathing Adora blinked. Her vision focused on her stout friend who stood before her.

She brushed a hair out of her face, "Sorry-" she continued panting, trying to catch her breath, "I didn't see you."

"Yeah I can tell." The edge of Glimmer's mouth perked a bit.

Adora dug her sword into the ground and rested her hand on her hip. Glimmer continued, "Are you alright? You look kind of on

edge.” She raised her hands and a tray of two glasses came into view.

“Those are?” Adora tilted her head and ignored the question.

“Lemonade, silly. You’ve been working so hard out here. Take a break, I have something I need to tell you anyway.” Glimmer held out the tray, waiting for Adora to grab her glass.

She only raised a brow, “Is that an order?”

“No but I will make it if you don’t rest for at least five minutes.”

“Ugh, yes your highness.” Adora chuckled and grabbed her glass.

Glimmer took hers and placed the tray under her arm before giving Adora a playful nudge, “Don’t call me that. I don’t want to hear that title coming from you.”

“Yes.” Adora smiled, “Your majesty, my humblest apologies. Allow me to relax in your presence.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes, a smile plastered across her face. She sat on the ground and patted the grass next to her.

Adora took the message and settled herself down, “I don’t think queens are supposed to sit on the grass.”

“Well, if I’m queen I can do what I want. Besides is only a temporary title until-”

Adora’s heart fell, “I don’t think-”

Glimmer quickly interjected, “Well enough about that. I just came here to talk to you, not to speculate.”

“Big word Glimmer.” Adora joked.

“I know.” She said with a smile, “Anyway, big news, There’s going to be a ball here for the winter solstice.”

That caught Adora completely off guard, “The winter what- What are you talking about?”

The sun had started to set.

Glimmer laid back with her hands behind her head, “You're invited.”

Adora clicked her tongue, “Answer my question.”

Glimmer let out a small giggle, “It's for my birthday, well Bow said that it was for my birthday.”

“Oh, that’s great. Have you guys started planning?”

“Yes, well. Just the basics like the theme, the location, you know the good stuff.”

“I don’t know the good stuff.” Adora shook her head. “If I'm invited I need to know the basics as well.”

“Well, the theme is…masquerade. ”

“Masquerade?” Adora threw a look of bewilderment, “What does that even mean?” She ran a hand through her hair down her face.

Glimmer started laughing and brought her hand up to Adora’s shoulder for support, “Remember when we liberated that village that was super far east? The party that they held was called a masquerade; one where everyone wears a mask as a disguise.”

Adora groaned, “That was really cool, but do you know how bad that is for security? ”

“Uh,” a small flush gathered on Glimmer’s cheeks, “Yes, but...I always wanted to host one ever since then- a masquerade.” her voice died as she got to the end.

“Is that what you really want?’

“Yes.” Glimmer said, with a little exasperation.

“Great….” Eventually Adora gave up all reason, “Well, if that’s what you want then I'm not going to stop you.”

“You couldn’t anyways,” Glimmer teased.

“Whatever,” Adora rolled her eyes, unable to prevent a grin of her own from spreading, “I’m assuming you’re going to use the ballroom then? How in the world are you going to decorate that?”

“Not the ballroom, we plan on using the court in the great hall.”

“Oh so this is going to be big?” Adora widened her eyes with earnest curiosity peeking through.

Glimmer mimicked the same action, “Of course it is.” she smiled, “It's my birthday after all.”

“Of course, how dare I assume otherwise?” Adora collected herself and then asked the next question on her mind, “But like I said, how are you going to decorate it?”

A wave of silence followed, “I was thinking of a dark theme, like the night or something."

“Why the night?” Adora shifted attention all onto her friend.

Glimmer fumbled over her next words, “Well, I wanted it to be winter theme, but Bow said that would be too similar to the Princess prom even thought that was years ago-” she doesn’t event finish her tangent, only huffed out her frustration, “I guess the time when we went to the observatory inspired me or something, you know when you pointed out all the stars and constellations.”

Adora looked up at the evening sky, the fading orange was giving way to deep reds and indigos. She took a breath, “You were paying attention?”

A giggle, “Yeah, you looked really passionate about it, you had a look in your eyes- I don’t know how to describe it.”

The words reverberated in Adora’s head as she was taken back to memories of the Fright Zone. The evening sky had been in a near constant state of dark red and orange. When night did come, stars were scarce. Just everlasting and ever looming darkness. Adora recalled the awestruck feeling that swarmed her when she first saw the night sky littered with stars. She had spent countless nights gazing up at them, taking in their beauty.

Once in the library she had found a book about them. Figuring out their positions and constellations had been her favorite past time when sleep evaded her. Many nights Adora wished she could share her sight and knowledge with her past friend. Somedays, Adora would hope that she would be sitting on the same guardrail in the Fright Zone and watch the night sky with her. Then the cruel wave of reality would always hit her and bring her back. But the fact that they would both fall asleep under the same sky brought her peace. And sleep soon followed.

“Adora?”

She snapped back into the present, “Huh? Oh yes Glimmer?”

She sighed, “There you go again, always in a daze. Are you sure you are alright?”

“I’m fine.” Adora tried to look into Glimmer’s eyes with the sincerity she wished to convey, but her face betrayed her.

“You suck at lying.”

“Right back at you, Glim.”

“Ew, don’t call me that.” the queen scrunched her nose.

Adora laughed and took a sip of her lemonade, “Yes, your majesty.” a scoff, “Anyways, this isn’t about me, what else is going on with the ball? Who’s on the invite list?”

Glimmer crossed her legs and brought up her fingers, starting to count from them, “I was thinking, everyone from the Princess alliance, a few diplomats from neutral territories, maybe a couple of citizens we know from the rebellion and…” She put her hand down onto her thigh, “And Entrapta.”

Adora practically shot up, “Entrapta? Are you serious?”

The queen narrowed her eyes, “Very.”

“Why- Why do you think she’ll attend this time around?”

“I don’t, I just need her to get out of the western wing basement for once.” Glimmer sighed and buried her face into her hands, “I am really worried about her. The guards say that she's getting worse, that she rambles to herself and barely even talks to them.”

Adora paused as if to solidify her next thought, “Last time I visited her, she worked the whole time…” she nodded to herself, “I agree something needs to be done about this.”

Glimmer removed her hands and let her shoulders drop, “And I want to help her really badly but it’s so hard with everything going on...”

Adora understood and got up, “I could try to talk to her?”

“If you could, Adora, Please?” Glimmer stood up as well.

“Alright, but I can’t guarantee she’ll come around.”

Glimmer’s frown hardened, her frustration threatened to seep through her eyes, “Entrapta’s losing herself…and there is nothing I can do to help it.”

“Glimmer, Just- We have to keep working with her.” Adora shifted her weight, “I’ll go visit her tomorrow morning alright? I’ll see what she says.”

“Okay.” she said with an affirmative sigh, “It's getting late anyway. I’m going to attend to more ball requirements, and send supply aid for some villages in the west.” The queen gave Adora a helpless smile, “See you around?”

“Yeah, I’ll just stay here for a bit.” Both dejected, nothing could be said more.

Glimmer teleported away, leaving her glass of lemonade. It was still nearly full. Adora let out a heavy sigh and sat back onto the ground. With Adora’s arms hugging her legs to her chest, she took deep breaths, trying to regulate the surging emotions.

Time eventually trudged forward, being in her mind though, Adora felt like none had passed at all. Night devoured the sky, but she paid no mind to the darkness. In the midst of her thoughts, she felt the urge to look up, and the stars were beautiful. Lost in their brilliance, Adora caught herself hypnotized. She recounted all of the constellations she found and the names of the stars, as if her old friend was listening right by her. With the night came a cool breeze. The wind whipped against her, carrying chill and the sound of a familiar chuckle.

Adora almost snapped her neck, looking behind her. Reaching for her sword, she stood up with urgency and scanned the area. Her eyes found nothing, and relief overcame her with a sense of shame. Burying, her head in a hand, she let out a cruel laugh. Being frightened by the wind was a new one and Adora couldn’t help but find the entirety of it all ridiculous. With a sigh she turned back around and her blood ran cold.

No, It can’t be.

Adora reached out, trying to grab the apparition in front of her. She blinked a couple of times and as quickly as it came, it disappeared. Adora couldn’t believe it; with her outstretched hand clutching nothing she brought it back to her chest. Pain bloomed from within, debilitating to the point where Adora was taken onto her knees, desperately grasping her chest, begging for mercy.

It hurts so bad-

Adora gasped, the pain sprouted into a new intensity. Tightening her already shut eyes, Adora could not erase the vision she had just seen.

Catra!

Please Catra, come back to me.

It doesn't have to be me,

but please-

Come back.

The pain subsided to the point where Adora could open her eyes. She was back, and so was the pain. Catra's face was soft and gentle; her wild hair rustled against the wind. Her blue and yellow eyes, deep and as infinite as the sky above, pierced Adora. Her form wasn't definitive, more like a hazy dream rather than corporal. Another jolt of pain shot through Adora. The vision was holding out her hand for Adora to grasp. The last thing she recalled was securing her hand into a firm grasp, not minding the scraping of Catra's sharp claws.

Adora woke up on her bed, her covers scrunched in her hands. Sitting up slightly confused, a dull ache lingered in her chest. She subconsciously brought her hand over her heart, it was rapidly beating and she felt for injury, but none was there. Arising from her bed, Adora made her way to bathe and wash her face. Looking into the mirror, years of battle and war had aged her. Resting her face only made her look displeased; fine lines had permanently set themselves into her cheeks and forehead. She hated what had stared back at her. The youth and vigor of Shera already started to feel like a stark contrast to what Adora had.

Dressing herself quickly, Adora took mental note of what she had to accomplish for the day.

I have to answer some letters requesting support, I need to visit Bow and see what his plans are for the ball, and I need to… visit Entrapta.

Adora left her bedroom and went into the next room which had been made into her office. She worked from the moment the sun rose to midday. Finally finishing her thirtieth letter, she got up with a stretch. Her bones cracked and popped, freeing her from hours of tension. With a heavy mind, Adora left and made her way down the great halls. Sunlight peered through the grand windows, lighting up the entire area. After turning a couple of corridors, Adora has halted suddenly, almost having run into Bow whose arms were full of scrolls and other various items.

Huh, what a coincidence.

"Bow!"

He turned around, his eyes buzzing with haste. Adora felt bad for stopping him, but she sought him out for a reason.

"Yes?" he replied.

"Got a minute?"

"No. Not really." He shook his head, "Nevermind I can spare you a few, what's up?"

"I was wondering about Glimmer's birthday ball, I need to know the details, who's going to be invited, set up for security, the arrangements…"

Bow was practically bouncing on his heels; his eyes darted all over the place waiting for Adora to finish, "Yeah, I'm taking some of this stuff to the court, come with me. I need help and I will explain to you the details along the way."

Adora took to his side and listened as he went on.

“I know that Glimmer must have told you some things yesterday, but I guess not all. The theme is masquerade, and we are decorating the great hall to look like the night. We will be having painters come in to paint murals on the walls and ceiling. But we are going to have lights everywhere, so it may look like a festival more than anything but oh well.”

Adora struggled a bit to keep up with his fast pace and speech, but she found room to intervene, “Okay so are you in charge of decorations?”

“Kinda- sorta- yes.” Bow didn’t look at Adora as he responded, “I am in charge of decorations and set up, Glimmer is in charge of entertainment, the music, food selection, anything that requires picking since you know, It is her birthday.”

“What does that leave me?”

He stopped, as if the mere sentence had stumped him, “Um, I don’t know.” He glanced around as if the answer would somehow find him, “Oh! Now I do. Didn’t you say something about security and guests? Glimmer will pick out a lot, but feel free to add some and make sure to do a background check on all of them.”

It sounded like a lofty task, but Adora was glad to have been useful.

“And can you do invitations? Glimmer wanted to, but her hands are swamped and so are mine.” Bow continued.

Adora gave him a soft smile, “Sure, I have security and invitations.”

“Thanks Adora,” Bow shot her a returning smile, “You’re awesome.”

They had made their way into the court. Great and big, it looked the same except with boxes, loose decorations and servants everywhere. It seemed as if everyone had started cleaning, to prepare for the decorations. Because of the size of the court,

Adora wasn't surprised that it might take them weeks to clean it. Everyone looked to be in a hurry even though the ball was still a good few months away.

I guess the sooner the better.

Bow set his stuff down and turned his attention to Adora, "Okay! Now let's get you busy."

Another smile and with eagerness, she planted herself right next to Bow examining his plans on the scrolls.

From the afternoon to the evening Bow had worked her like a dog, and her job had just begun. Adora's mind began to throb, just thinking about the amount of invitations she would have to send and the amount of guards she would have to deal with for background checks. Rubbing her temples, she exited the court gratefully. Just about to head off to the stables, Adora was hit with remembrance. She let out a sigh; guilt and a sense of responsibility filled her to the brim.

The walk to the most western wing in the near basement of the castle was a long one. Her loud footsteps echoed through the hall, light dust covered the walls and tapestry; nobody really came over here, and for good reason. Moonlight came through the windows, but then came to a halt and Adora came to a large winding of stairs. She groaned, having forgotten a torch, and thought to leave this ordeal for another day. But she felt an invisible push, mentally, and took a deep breath as she made her way down.

A dim light reflected off the walls, and mad chattering echoed back into Adora's ears. Entrapta was still in the basement, in her workshop and the guards who were supposed to keep her on schedule were obviously not doing their job. As Adora entered her eyes widened. A horrific stench swarmed her of crude oil and metal, her hand flew to her nose and with hesitant steps she moved forward.

Entrapta's workshop was just as messy as she was. Machines, wires and odd inventions were tossed everywhere. Blueprints and scrolls were lazily thrown and covered the ground as a second ground. Ink stains, Oil stains and what Adora wondered what could be food stains, also garnished the floor. The basement was enormous, about half the size of the throne and court combined, which was enough to fit all of her inventions, a subpar resting area, and the workshop. It was barely lit by some contraptions of Entrapta's; her face and figure was barely able to have been made out.

Entrapta was working on a scrap bot Adora had recently brought back from a tussle from the Horde. She was taking it apart, bolt by bolt and examining its chips, in fact it was a bot she had designed when she was still with the Horde.

So engrossed in her work, the scientist didn't hear Adora approach her or when she had tried to call her name. Adora had placed her hand on Entrapta's shoulder, she jolted as if she had been electrocuted by one of her own hanging wires. She turned around and lifted the shield from her face and looked at Adora with such eagerness, she felt her heart soar. Entrapta threw her arms around her.

"Adora! You came to see me!"

She reluctantly put her hands around Entrapta, wondering whether to fully immerse herself. Her heart gave, and so did she, squeezing Entrapta tightly. Careful not to inhale too deeply, Adora started formulating an idea on how to get her out. One idea arrived, and the more she thought, the more plausible it became.

"Yes, Entrapta I did." she said with affirmation.

"I'm so glad. I know you, Glimmer, and Bow are busy, but I thought you guys forgot about me."

"But I visited you four days ago."

"You did? Oh, guess I forgot."

Still in the arms of Entrapta, Adora looked at her and felt her heart sink. How her eyes used to shine with life with an unending vitality. What had she been running on down here? Adora quickly looked away and her eyes met some of the papers on the wall. Other than blueprints and designs, Adora found several drawings of her, and of Shera. Few were of Bow and Glimmer. There were some of another person who she had once researched to be Scorpia, a princess who's kingdom had given themselves over to the Horde. But, Adora's heart never failed to drop every time she saw the drawings of Catra.

Her eyes lingered on a picture. She was drawn in such a simple form, a stick figure with her signature hair spiraled out. A hand extended towards it, Adora realized that it was her own. She wanted it. It didn't matter how poorly drawn it was, it was Catra. That was Catra.

The picture was coming out of focus as tears welled in Adora's eyes. The dull pain returned, intensifying every second. The prior feelings which had come to surface caused Adora to fall. Her hands slid down Entrapta arms, stopping at her wrists.

"Adora?" Entrapta looked so worried, "Are you hurt? Are you alright?"

"I-I'm fine." Her voice cracked as she was choking back tears.

"Are you sure? You don't look too well, I can try and do something-"

"I said that I'm fine!" Adora winced at the force of her own voice; she withdrew her hands, "I'm fine." She gathered courage to stand up and face Entrapta, disregarding the pain and any other thoughts.

Adora knew that after Entrapta had been recovered from the Horde, she was not the same. Her room became messier with inventions and she began to ramble more. Glimmer got frustrated to the point where she gave her an entire west wing floor and

basement to work in and live above. But it was like Entrapta could not separate herself from when she was under the employ of the Horde. She lived and breathed to build bigger and better. The basement had practically become her home; Adora decided this couldn't go on for much longer.

"Entrapta, I need to talk to you."

"Oh, ok." She blinked a couple times after Adora did not follow up, "What about?"

Adora took a breath, "Glimmer's birthday is coming up-"

"Yeah! One of the guards told me about that. I'm fixing up old Holograms of Queen Angella to give to her."

Adora dismissed being cut off and sought to just continue, "Yes, well Glimmer actually told me what she wanted from you for her birthday."

"Really?" Entrapta looked slightly disappointed, but then returned to her energetic nature, "Okay then what does she want?"

Adora took Entrapta's hand into hers, and peered into her deeply, "She wants you to come to her birthday ball."

Entrapta's face visibly shifted. Her smile waned into a firm line, her eager eyes dimmed and she slowly removed her hands from Adora's, "I don't know. I mean finishing up the holograms is going to take a while, I might not be able to make it." Her words started to turn into a mindless ramble.

Adora seized Entrapa by her shoulders causing her to jump a bit, "Hey, Entrapta…please. She wants to see you so bad, me and Bow also want to see you. You have been down here so long, When's the last time you left the palace?"

She had nothing to respond to the question, Entrapta just held her head down, her face visibly conflicted.

“Why do you work so hard, Entrapta?”

She didn’t lift her head, “In the Horde being busy was good; I liked how Hordak treated me after I made something he liked. But then you guys rescued me, and told me that I didn't need to work as hard anymore… but I didn’t know what else to do other than build and make new things.”

“You could have hung out and talked to us. Me, Glimmer, and Bow all wanted to see you, but you holed yourself down here, and rejected us everytime we offered to go out. Why?”

Entrapta lifted her head, “The last time I stepped outside, everything was horrible and in chaos, and I-” She brought her arms up to her elbows, “I just- I can’t go out anymore, it scares me. So, I tried to just stay in the palace and talk with you guys but you all were so busy, and had to do other things; I figured that I’d just keep working, and I’ve gotten used to it I guess.” Entrapta lifted her head, “And Adora you wouldn’t even talk to anyone for a while.”

“What?” Adora tilted her head genuinely confused.

“I think you started that the night after you got me back from the Horde…you looked lost and miserable, and really really hurt. I’d asked you if you had gotten hit or stabbed but you didn’t even respond.”

To that Adora said nothing. Sitting in the silence, many words bubbled up Adora’s throat, yet they could not find themselves past her lips.

She tried to remember, how she looked, how she felt that day, yet no emotion showed itself. All Adora could remember was the after, how emptiness soon filled with hints of remorse. That final fight, she had confirmed Catra’s life and ended it too. Filling Adora to the brim with a suffocating despair and crushing guilt, distress overcame her and dragged her down into the abyss of grief. Facing an insurmountable depression, she didn't know if she

would survive. It was like she had to learn how to breathe again; how to live in a world without Catra.

Trying to bring something, any words forward, the dull pain in her chest returned. She felt pitiful looking for traces of Catra from wherever. Pulling her mind from rest and ease, to further torment herself into the depths of agony. Adora had to push down any and all thoughts about Catra; It was Entrapta in front of her now; she needed to focus on Entrapta- the present.

Adora grabbed Entrapta's hand and lightly squeezed it, "I'm so sorry Entrapta. I was not okay at that time and a terrible friend to you, but I really want to see you at the ball. Please, we all miss you."

She shuffled around uncomfortably for a couple of minutes, before she gave a sigh and a shy smile, "Okay. I'll think about it, just give me some time."

A faint smile peeked at the corners of Adora's mouth, "You have a couple of months, so don't think that you have to give me an answer now. If you say yes then I can help you get prepared and we can pick out your outfit. But if you say no then I'll help you with the hologram gift instead. Sound like a plan?'

"Yeah, I'd like that;" Entrapta gave a loopy smile, "thanks Adora."

"Of course. Any time Entrapta." Adora pulled her into another hug, and sensed the heaviness of her heart lift ever so slightly.

The walk back to her bedroom was an easier one than coming down. Adora's feet didn't drag, her mind was clear for once. She found her bedroom in ease and did her nightly routine. Slipping on a night gown, Adora made her way to bed. Glad that her muscles finally relaxed, they revealed her true exhaustion. She was delighted to fall into a dreamless slumber.

It came to a point where months meshed together; days and happenings were a whirlwind of instances rather than time. Such was typical for the winter. The days felt shorter, but the hours

were still just as long. Every winter was a season of reminisce and grief for Adora. Since Catra's absence, everyday, minute, hour, second was painful, but like with all things time carried, it became bearable. The pain never really left. It just came in waves. It was a reminder that Adora could still feel, no longer empty, no longer resigned to a fate of endless dance. Catra had made her full again, but it is within the same regard that Adora knew that she would never feel whole again.

She had tried to kill her love, and run on hate; how it overtook her and burned her alive. Feeding on loss and anger, it was self-sufficient by her own will and the continuous bad actions of Catra. Like a phoenix ignited by the death, everything she killed rose from its ashes, running on the remains of her regrets.

Despite the event being years passed, it was once again that fateful day that marked one more year without Catra. Somehow Adora had made it, she didn't want to, she didn't know that she could, but she made it.

The room was a bit chillier than what Adora would have liked to have woken up to. Glimmer's birthday ball was to have taken place the next day. All invites, security checks and sweeps had been done. Adora thought to have gotten up, but it was as if she was cemented onto her bed. She tossed and turned, her mind was strangely clear but there was no drive to will herself out from under her sheets.

Being lazy wasn't a trait that Adora liked to flaunt, but she felt that this wasn't a spout of laziness. If that was the case then she would have been lazy for years.

A soft knock came to her door. Adora propped herself onto her elbows, "Come in."

To her surprise, it was Bow. In his hands he had a tray of orange juice and a few sandwiches.

“Hey, Adora. Glimmer and I noticed that you didn’t come down for breakfast, or lunch, like you said you would yesterday. We thought you might be sick so we made you a little something.”

Lunch?

Adora looked out to one of her windows, the sun was indeed high enough for it to be well into the afternoon.

“Oh, shoot I’m sorry, I clearly overslept.” Adora tried to quickly change the subject, “Was Entrapta there?”

“Yes she was there.”

Adora clicked her tongue, feigning disappointment , “Ah, I’m upset that I missed that, but I am glad to hear she was there.” she let a smile show.

Bow placed the tray down, came over to Adora’s bed and sat himself down, “I don’t know how you managed to get her out of her cave, but I'm glad you did. This time around she even helped with the sandwiches.”

“She did?” Adora said pleasantly surprised.

“Yep, she pulled out a triangular ruler and said ‘I don’t know if she’ll want equal, scalene or isosceles so we should give her all just to make sure.’” Bow let out a small laugh, “and I was like, ‘Okay, Entrapta.’ Yeah, she’s been a blast.” Bow then faced Adora, sincerity painted within his face, “Anyway, how are you holding up?”

Adora gave her response a genuine thought, “I’m doing fine. I think I was just more tired than I thought, you know, finishing everything on my end for Glimmer’s ball.”

Bow’s mouth slightly dipped, then fixed, “Let me know if you start feeling that tired often; you know it's not good Adora…Actually, now that I think about it, you always sleep more around this time of the year. Are you a bear?” he chuckled.

“Yes, and I'm in hibernation. Thank you for bringing me food, this should last me through the winter.” Adora chuckled as well.

Bow let out a deeper laugh and handed Adora a sandwich. She sat up and took it, starting with small nibbles.

“Well, excuse me for disturbing your sleep. I also came up here to let you know that the ensemble that will be playing for Glimmer’s ball is practicing soon and they should be for a good while.”

“Gotcha. Thanks for the heads up.”

Bow got up and began making his way towards the door, “No problem, let me know if you need anything, and thank you for everything you’ve done to help with Glimmer’s party. She really appreciates it.”

“Ahh, it's nothing; she’s my friend, why wouldn’t I help out?” Bow shot Adora another smile and gently closed her door on his way out.

Throughout the lunch, Adora found motivation to rise and get started with her day. She washed and dressed. Her mind tossed a couple of ideas around on how to spend her rest of her free time. The music that Bow had warned her about just began to play when suddenly, her door burst open. Adora made a quick dive for her sword, but it just turned out to be Entrapta wanting her to come down to see the finished versions of the Queen Angella holographs.

The trip to the western wing basement was a better one than months prior. It looked better after Adora had put in an order to have it cleaned and guilt no longer reigned her mind. Since Adora had been working with Entrapta, she actually started improving, slowly but surely. Some days she had to drag her from the basement to see actual life; others she came willingly, but the day she got Entrapta to eat breakfast with the group, Adora was obscenely elated. Entrapta had also begun sleeping in her room despite her still working into the ungodly hours of the night.

Nevertheless, she ate regularly and interacted with others more; for that Adora was content and proud.

“Good work Entrapta.” Adora said seeing the nearly life-like image of the former queen, “You did an awesome job.”

“Really?” Entrapta said eager and eyes wide.

“Yes. This is amazing, Glimmer is going to love it.”

“...Thank you for telling me that.”

Adora gave Entrapta another nod of approval and she immediately buried herself under “finishing touches”. After Adora made her way from the basement, she could still manage to hear faint notes of the music above. She was stopped by a guard who reported that Glimmer was looking for her in her dressing room. It took traveling the distance of nearly the entire palace to get to the queen.

Upon opening the door Adora was taken aback. Glimmer was dressed in a beautiful slim fit gown, dark as night and decorated in stars that would fade in and out everytime she moved.

Adora’s eyes shone in wonder, “Wow. Glimmer, you look great.”

The queen turned, “Thank you Adora.” a small blush crept onto her face, “I called you over here so that you can try on this dress I made you.” She motioned to a white gown.

“Wait, what about my other one?”

“Adora,” Glimmer looked at her as if she was helpless, “I told you this a million times, you will not be wearing the same dress you wore to the princess prom on my birthday.”

“But that’s a waste of a perfectly good dress.”

“Well that's just too bad then.” She huffed and put her hands on her hips, “Come on Adora hurry up and get changed, I want to

see how it looks on you."

She did as she was told and surprisingly everything was nearly a perfect fit. Glimmer showered her with compliments as the attendants poked and prodded her. After a good while, Adora, still bashful, had a note passed to her which was received by Glimmer. Reading the first few words drew a sigh from Adora's lips.

"Some of the guests that arrived in Brightmoon early require assistance-"

Glimmer gave a small giggle which dragged an annoyed look out of Adora, "I guess you have your hands full for today."

Ugh, she quickly corrected her thoughts, *Its for the people- its for the people-*

"Alright." Adora refolded the note and began to instruct the attendants to take off her attire, "I guess I got to go but I'll see you at dinner?"

A subtle frown found itself onto the face of the queen, "Sorry, I probably won't even have time for dinner, I'm handling last minute additions and changes."

"That's okay." Adora had slipped on her old outfit and started to take her leave, "Then I'll see you tomorrow, Glim."

"I told you not to call me that!"

The sound of Adora's laughter echoed amongst the halls.

Coming back for the hours of servicing nobles, breaking disputes and seeing invitees, t he long day had drained Adora entirely, and yet she could feel the oncoming of another long night. Still, the faint trills of flutes lingered in the air. After brushing her hair for the night, she slipped into bed, and stared at her ceiling.

That chilly night was one night of too many, when her thoughts had been of sorrows and woes. Letting her mind wander, far and

far, it reached the deepest pits of her memory and surfaced things she wished she had forgotten.

Catra was tiny, her wild hair was not yet tamed and her eyes were fresh with tears. Adora was right at her side, staring deeply and waiting for the right words to come to her. Wrapped in a blanket the feline looked down at the floor unable to face Adora. Her ears twitched as she picked up the familiarity of her friend's voice.

"It doesn't matter what they do to us. Ya'know? You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing bad can really happen as long as we have each other" With big eyes full of concern, young Adora reached over and lightly placed her hand over Catra.

'You promise?" her voice was unsure, a plea.

"I promise." And it came so naturally just like the hug they pulled each other into after they exchanged words.

The image held for a steady beat as Adora tried to recall the warmth of that hug. Hands hugging her body, she shivered at the cold; she reached over, but Catra wasn't there.

Bubbling of pain rose in increments, steadily climbing from her chest to her throat. It was the pain of swallowing a cry, as tears threatened to break. Her hands gathered sheets and tightened them in her grip. Rising and collapsing her chest felt it was caving in on itself; Adora once again was forgetting how to breathe. If this is what it meant to be alive without Catra, then surely she wasn't living.

Adora had stayed true to her promise; she had looked out for Catra. She was her first and her last thought in battle. If she couldn't find Catra then surely she would come to her. Like magnets, they were compelled to each other nearly colliding, yet every time they met they repelled each other with great force. Catra was her comfort and then anguish, her delight and then despair, her forsaken longing and then painful ache. Yet, even in

death, Catra was still causing her pain, trapping her just as she so long ago wished her torment.

But if I were to stop loving you

I'd think I'd lose a part of myself.

All the moments of time in which they occupied together, flashed across Adora's memory. She sank herself deeper into her bed unable to withstand the crushing weight.

I don't want to move on

I don't think I can

…How could I ever?

She remembered how they would hold each other through storms and train together. Then came Shera, Brightmoon the rebellion and they grew farther and farther apart. Catra was so far away, but Adora could keep going knowing that she was alive.

She remembered the way Catra's tail moved when she was excited, how it would puff when she got scared or found a mouse. The twitching of her ears upon hearing her voice, her purrs during a peaceful night. Everything about Catra invaded her memories; her laugh, her smile, her hair, her eyes, her concern, her teasing, her hugs, her tears, her excitement, her pain, her anger.

Her insults, her torment, her cruelty, her scratches, her vengefulness, her bitterness, her selfishness, her instability, her greed, her ruthlessness.

Despite the agony Catra's presence and lack thereof caused Adora, still, she wished to hold her once more, just for one more night; for remembrance of what they were, and acceptance of what they had become, then maybe when day broke, she could let go.

Had Adora stayed with Catra then maybe this reality wouldn't have come to pass.

She would be wrong, going against everything she believed in and fought for.

But at least she wouldn't be alone that night.

Adora, hands hugging her body, shivered at the cold. She reached over. but Catra wasn't there.

The same night continued as the eve of the ball. Awake, Adora was pulled from her mind to the sound of music drifting into her ears. She heard the ringing of bells and the airy melody of a flute calling for her. Adora sat up, her white nightgown shifted and fell to her ankles, her tousled hair trailed down her back. Violins lured her from bed, enchanting her into a daze. She followed the sound as the music of the ensemble became louder. Her feet were light, as if she was walking on clouds and moving through a haze. No one else came from their rooms to source the song; she was alone in her waltz to the sound. The dark blue halls were stained with streaks of moonlight radiating from the windows covering the floors and lighting the way to the court.

Adora, enraptured by every note that played, walked until she came upon the great doors of the court. The harmonies of the instruments wrapped her in such awe, she pressed her ear against to listen more closely. Surely the band could not go on from the night into the dawn of the next day. With a firm push she opened the doors, and beheld the sights in front of her.

Adora had monitored the decoration of the court, but had not seen its recent installments.

Truly it was night. Within the ceiling held the moon and the countless stars of the sky. The darkness, a stunning contrast to the illumination overhead, enhanced the twinkling stars and as far as Adora could see they were even in the right position. Drapes a fine sheen and of a silvery-white hung from the walls accenting

the grand windows. The floor held streaks of gold, circling and entwining with each other. But, it was as if the ground and sky were one and endless, made of a glassy polished material, Adora could see herself and the painted ceiling mural above her. She stood in the middle of it all enthralled by the view as the sweet timbres of each instrument carried throughout the court.

She heard a familiar gentle laugh, and slowly turned her head to meet the owner of the sound.

Adora was met by an outstretched hand, gloved in white; she trailed her eyes upwards.

"Hey, Adora."

Catra's suit was white, pure and only white. She looked older, but still had a mischievous youth to her. Her cropped slicked back hair brought out her yellow and blue eyes, which were all the more hardened and piercing. Her face had settled into sternness and definition of a hauntingly attractive degree. The confidence and tenderness Catra carried herself with melted Adora.

Her mind drew to a blank, stunned by who had greeted her. Adora's heart started beating faster, her mind began to race. She thought that it all had to be a dream. She looked around and despite clearly hearing the music of a waltz there was no ensemble to be seen. Engulfing the court, it echoed and enchanted Adora. Her eyes came back to Catra, who was still surprisingly patiently waiting for her hand.

Catra's mouth quirked into a full blown smile, "Come on slowpoke, we haven't got all night."

Adora wanted to fall into Catra's arms, yet a creeping fear of falling into nothing overrode her impulse. With a shaky hand, hers found solace in Catra's, who suddenly grabbed her and pulled her in by the waist. Their dance had begun.

"Catra, is it really you?" Adora asked, astonished, still in disbelief.

Her face glistened as they moved into the moonlight, “Of course,” her voice was oddly soft and honeyed, “Who else would I be?”

Adora laughed, it was joyful and reverberated throughout the hall. The laughter twisted into sobs, light and full of relief, Adora failed to hold it back.

“Aw, come on don’t cry.” Catra smirked, “I didn’t think you’d be this excited to see me.”

Adora let out another laugh in between sobs, “I missed you, you idiot…I really missed you.”

Catra spun Adora, the white of her own gown fluttered behind her. Into a dip she and her shared a lingering gaze, one of longing, fueled by passion. A loving smile from Catra seized Adora and once more, her heart. The music was a spell, an enchantment. Dreamy in sound, the sweet airy notes carried through the air. As they danced, Adora was taken in her mind somewhere beyond what was her present.

“Am I dreaming? Am I awake?” Adora blinked many times.

Catra tilted her head slightly, “Are we not dancing right now?”

“Well I could still do that in a dream, or I might be sleep walking-” Catra lightly flicked her head.

“Just dance with me, for a bit longer this time.”

And so they did. Catra was dancing better than what Adora had previously known from her memories. That was a memory far away and from such a long time ago, yet Adora held onto it dearly. In spite of the animosity they shared at the time, it felt tame compared to the complexity they grew up to.

The appreciation of each other’s presence was interrupted by Catra’s laugh, her same old laugh, “Why are you looking at me like that?” Her voice was all over in pitch, nervous more likely.

“Like what?”

“Like your head is stuck in the clouds.” Catra jested.

Adora chuckled, “I am just so happy, and you look so beautiful.”

A steady blush rose to Catra’s cheeks, “Thanks.”

It was as if they were whisked away to a time unknown to them both; a reality once desired and unachievable. Catra stared up at Adora, she no longer had the look of painful endearment. Adora looked down at Catra, stunned by the kindness and grace she displayed.

Catra twirled her partner, and Adora landed right back into her arms, “I’m sorry that I left you.”

“I know, and,” Remorse filled every word, “I am sorry for everything. I know that doesn’t make up for half of the things I did but-”

“It's a start.” Adora said.

“I always wanted to say it, apologize at least.”

The moon shone on them through the windows, lighting their path as they waltzed in perfect sync. There were still so many unspoken words, failed promises, so much pain, yet the two just danced, never once averting their eyes.

Adora stared hard at Catra, trying to read whatever was in her eyes. But all she found was peace, a melancholy peace, “It hurts without you.”

“And I could tell it hurt with me.” Catra brushed a stray hair behind Adora’s ear and gave her a quaint smile.

“But I need you Catra, I don’t think- I don’t know-.” Adora dropped her arms and the two held their place, “You hate me. You have every right to, but…”

Catra bore into Adora, with a look of her own, “Adora, I don’t hate you. “

“But you said-”

“I could never hate you.”

Adora felt herself getting choked up again, “Even after what I did to you?”

“Pissed? Oh yeah,” Catra grinned at that, “but hate?...not even if I wanted to.”

Adora broke. Cries, quiet and mournful, filled in for any words might have been said. Catra pulled Adora into a chilling hug, letting her weep herself empty. Adora’s knees began to buckle, but Catra held firm, supporting her through heavy sobs, reassuring her with every wail.

“I only heard that you hated me. I thought for so long that you-you hated me.”

Catra was silent until Adora had calmed down a bit, “I tried to convince you before myself, but I was wrong, I wasn’t right and I’m sorry. Adora, I really am.”

Adora felt the sensation of her hair being soothed in a way she used to pet Catra, she let out a small laugh at the memory.

“Now you're laughing?” Catra playfully teased, her voice soft and tender, “Jeez, what's wrong with you?”

Adora sniffled and more laughs escaped, “No, it's what’s wrong with you?”

The sound of doors flailing open and a rush of a cool breeze swarmed the two; a door leading towards the out door balcony had opened.

Catra looked at Adora with curiosity in response to her small grin, she had an idea.

“Come with me,” she said, “I want to show you the stars.”

The waltz came to a close, and Adora took Catra in. Under the moon, she was a dream, ethereal as the light shone on her fur and brightened her eyes. Adora brought her hand up to Catra’s cheek. Naturally she fell into it, even cupping Adora’s hand with her own. She was cold; underneath all of that fur, she was cold.

Catra took Adora’s hand and led her outside onto the balcony, and they placed their hands on the rails leaning closer to the stars. Together they met under the same sky.

Surprisingly, Catra was the one to speak first, “The days when I would travel outside the Fright Zone, I used to look up at the stars and try to count them.” shelaughed, “That got boring pretty quick so then I would just stare at them.” she paused, “I always wondered if you would look at them too or if even cared for sappy things like that.”

“You know me too well…Of course I did.” Adora continued, “I was waiting for you to join the rebellion so that I could show them to you…But now, you beat me to it.”

Catra turned to face Adora, “Looks like you were too slow this time.”

A moment passed.

Catra leaned back against the rail, Adora leaned forward.

“Catra,” Adora swallowed any pride, guilt or shame, “Why don’t you hate me?”

She cut her eyes, weighing the question then looked back at Adora and smiled.

“Because I love you, Adora.”

It was as beautiful as a night of shooting stars, the way Adora lit up. All she could do was stare and gawk as Catra let out a big laugh.

“I can’t believe I have to spell it out for you.” Catra kept on laughing and even brought her hand up to her face. Adora couldn’t break past her astonishment.

“You love me?”

It was as if time froze, waiting in anticipation of this moment.

“Yeah, you idiot.” Catra chuckled, “Why else would I be here?”

Adora lost the fight within herself and resigned to doing what she had initially wanted to do since the night began. She reached down and grabbed Catra by her chin, seizing her in a chilling kiss. Catra’s eyes went wide, she melted into it soon after. Her hand found its place on Adora’s cheek. Soft, natural light illuminated the two as they embraced each other, holding on desperately not wanting to be the first to let go.

Finally, their lips parted and Adora stared at Catra, mind fuzzy and enamored. She could hear the pounding of her heart in her ears. Catra smiled, eyes moving from Adora’s lips to her eyes.

“We are horrible together.”

“And we are terrible apart.”

Catra took a fraction of Adora in which she would never be able to recover, but Adora found a revolutionary peace in that, Catra had something of hers in which she took with her to the great beyond. In return, Adora finally had something of Catra’s she could carry forever, her love. From outside the music had begun to dwindle bringing its enchantment to a close.

“Can I hug you again? Please?” Adora asked and Catra scoffed as if that was the stupidest question she had ever heard; they embraced each other again.

Adora held Catra like the removal of a single finger would shatter her into a million pieces. She found her place in the crook of Catra's neck, and let out a shaky breath; her partner was cold to the touch.

"I think we've been out here for too long, let's go back in and heat up." Adora's voice was barely above a whisper but her affection was prominent. She removed her head and smiled.

Adora would never forget the way Catra's face darkened and blanked in utter dismay. Loosening her grip and letting her arms fall, Adora blinked multiple times. Catra was still there but her form was beginning to warp into an after image.

Catra took Adora's hand and interlaced it with her own, she placed a gentle kiss onto it, one that Adora could barely feel. She took her hand and then pressed it against her chest.

It was still.

Pure terror filled Adora to the brim, panic rose and threatened to corrupt her and that very moment, "Catra?" her eyes were wide full of denial, like her world was falling apart.

Catra with sudden urgency wrapped her hand around Adora's head and pulled her into another kiss. It was desperate, rushed, and a goodbye.

Adora leaned into it with the same fervor. Her hand started to tingle and the feeling of Catra's began to lighten until it felt as if she was holding onto nothing. Adora tightened her eyes focusing on the remaining sensation she could feel from Catra. When Adora felt Catra leave her lips, she opened her eyes and tried to reach out once more but her hand slipped through the mirage. She watched as Catra faded into the light of the moon.

No. No.. No…

"NO!"

The scream was raw, guttural, a cry.

Adora had draped herself over the balcony railing, failing to capture the essence of light that Catra had vanished into. Unmoving for minutes, she suddenly slumped onto the floor, breathing heavily to regain her composure. Tears threatened to spill and she tried to hold them back by biting her lip. Blood spilled onto the ground, and then followed tears, unable to kill whatever had reignited in her. A spark of burning want was extinguished by the cool wave of reality. Adora held up a hand up to her lips, recounting the feeling of Catra and her passion. She kissed her fingers, but it was not the same.

End Notes

Will I ever be able to write characters in character?
The world may never know.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!